

floats the boat. And float the boat it did, and then some. Pinterest, a year after it started, had moved from selling clothes to giving people a beautiful collection display space, had grown 2000 per cent, and had amassed a valuation of \$1.5 billion.

Groupon

Then there is tale of one of the most interesting companies of recent times – Groupon. There was a time when coupons were uncool. But Andrew Mason did not like this, and built an empire on the idea. For the uninitiated, Groupon provide steep discount listings as coupons from small business owners. And amazingly, people love it. What is less amazing is that people did not like the previous iteration of the idea – ThePoint. It was like Kickstarter, except it didn't work, and had no real plans to do so either. The site, launched in 2007, let you start campaigns, and ask people to pledge money to the idea as a group – it only worked after a “tipping point” number of people agreed to participate. By delaying action until enough people were behind the idea, ThePoint tapped into one of the earliest emotions known to man –



laziness. Put simply, not enough people really got things done. The feelings of the founders would have been legendary when they came to know about the darned Kickstarter.com – which is practically funding everything other than multibillion dollar companies. Exactly why Andrew and his group did not follow a similar no-frills approach is beyond the level of intelligence that we can muster to think about it. But we're sure there couldn't have been too many regrets, because they later went on to create an entire industry sub-segment cool again, and inspire thousands to try to copy them and follow their dreams (and eventually fail).

Flickr

If you were anywhere near the internet five years ago, you've heard of Flickr. It is an online photo sharing repository. But did you know that it started out as an MMPORPG? Wait, it gets weirder. Newlywed couple Caterina Fake and Stewart Butterfield were developing a game called 'Game Neverending'. Described by the founders as part-whimsy and part-meta-reality, the game had a hard time collecting any sort of industry funding. The couple mortgaged their house and borrowed from friends and family to keep



the idea afloat, but they couldn't get this model to any reasonable scale. So, while slowly watching their dream drown in the sad realms of reality, they figured out something extraordinary – one of the best-liked parts of an online game, they thought, was, wait for it, the chat-room. So they thought they would build a cool chat service, full of pictures and everything. But this is the classic chicken-and-egg problem – for people to get into a messenger service, their friends should already be there. So they thought they would start it off as a social network that was based around pictures – essentially an organization structure for photographers, where they could tag and organize pictures, as well as share them. The idea exploded enough to turn an in-debt game into a \$40 million company that was bought by Yahoo! in 2005. Little did the



founders know that the idea wasn't done exploding yet, and that it would go on to become a multi-billion dollar business in its own right, and that suffocating this service would be the downfall of Yahoo!.

Twitter

No discussion of startup pivots is complete if we do not get around to talking about Twitter. It was supposed to be a podcasting service, called Odeo, and eventually rule the world. But when Apple unleashed podcasting on to the world via iTunes, they did what any non-BS-peddling bunch of entrepreneurs would do in the situation – they thought it was the end, and decided to throw it all away. Well, that, and they began work on an instant messaging service that would actually limit the number of words that you can put into a message – thereby also confirming the hypothesis that deep down, the world just loves being



told what to do. And then they started gathering spotlight as more and more people flocked to check out this 'next great thing'. And they're still flapping and flocking all around, if you pardon the pun, in twitter-land. A happily-ever-after story if there ever was one.

Instagram

Instagram is a success story that continues to amaze and baffle people all over the world, all in their retro-filter glory. But the amazing thing is, it was not meant to be a gimmicky photo sharing app at all. It was supposed to be an all-serious location based social network called Burbn, and that was what it was. Which also let users upload pictures of the places that they had been to. So essentially Foursquare with better photos. But they realized

